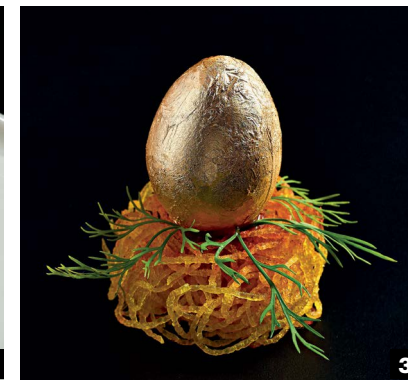




1 **"Sept Bites" *vazhai* (banana), *kollu* (horse-gram millet), *dangar ellu* at Farmlore**

2 **Caesar Salad in Bloom by Osteria Francescana**

3 **Golden Egg, a signature dish served at Raga By Gaggan**

WHEN ITALIAN CHEF Massimo Bottura—whose three-Michelin-starred Osteria Francescana in Modena has been named the world's best restaurant twice—came to New Delhi in August, a meal prepared by him came with a price tag of ₹75,000 plus taxes per person. The dinner, organised by Culinary Culture at The Leela Palace, New Delhi, was among the most exclusive culinary events in the country. The evening was sold out well ahead of the event, reflecting the appetite for an experience that, until recently, would have seemed prohibitively expensive to most Indian diners.

Around the same weekend, another celebrated chef, Takahiko 'Taka' Kondo of Gucci Osteria in Florence (also owned by Massimo Bottura in partership with Gucci), was in Delhi preparing a special meal. But this was not an event for which diners could purchase tickets. Organised by Conosh, at Upstairs at Indian Accent, the entire experience was bought over by a financial institution for its clients, with 100 guests entertained over two evenings.

The two events illustrate how dramatically India's fine-dining landscape is changing. On the one hand, consumers are willing to spend extraordinary sums for an evening with an internationally acclaimed chef. On the other hand, luxury brands and corporate houses are increasingly treating access to exclusive culinary experiences as a reward for their most valued customers.

Not too long ago, spending ₹4,000-5,000 per person on a meal would have been considered extravagant, and it still is, by most of the country. However, today, there is a growing segment of Indian consumers willing to pay upwards of ₹10,000 to as high as ₹50,000 for a dining experience that promises something beyond good food.

Raaj Sanghvi, CEO of Culinary Culture, which has brought close to 100 international chefs to India since 2018, has witnessed this transformation first-hand.

"When we started, a ticket in the ₹8,000-12,000 range was considered very expensive. Today, Indian diners have matured and are sometimes ready to pay